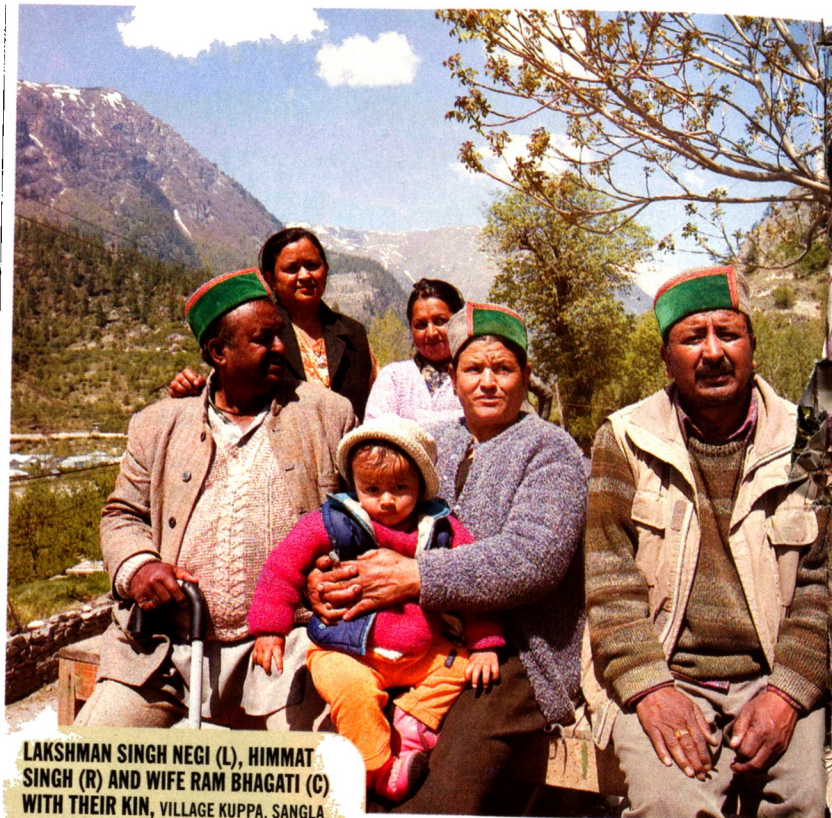


society & the arts POLYANDRY

"Common marriages involve a division of love and labour," says Rattan. Sumriti, 37, takes pride in observing *karva chauth* fast for her two spouses. "It takes a lot of mutual understanding and sacrifice," she adds.

The polyandrous wedlock has its own codes of privacy. For instance, the male sibling's Kinnauri cap hung outside the bedroom door is a sign that he is having sex with the common wife, which other siblings respect. Barring denial of the right of inheritance, the Kinnauri women have traditionally enjoyed cultural freedom in the matter of choosing life partner or partners. "The girl's consent is a paramount prerequisite for a common marriage," says Ranchan Devi, up-pradhan of Katgaon.

That is also reflected in the age-old practice of *Daroch Phimu*, in which an adult boy takes away an adult girl of his liking from the village fair or public place. The runaway couple consummate their relationship before the male's relatives make a formal proposal of marriage to the girl's parents by presenting a bottle of local brew *Fasur* in a ceremony called *botal pooja*. Once the girl's family agrees, which it invariably does, the formal marriage is solemnised. A boy refusing to marry the runaway girl invites the wrath of the panchayat which imposes a fine on the boy's family depending upon its social status. Higher the status, more the fine, in a practice called *izzat wapsi karna*. In many cases, the runaway couple graduate into a polyandrous relationship by roping in one or more brothers of the spouse. Exemplifying the trend is the case of Sunita Devi, who was 17 years old when she was taken away by Kirpa Ram from a fair in Kamru village in 1990. Later, she tied the nuptial knot with both Kirpa Ram and his younger brother Amar Singh. Native of Katgaon, the trio now has four children that has prevented the fragmentation of their meagre land. "It's a tough job to keep two husbands happy but I have learnt the trick with time," she says, with an impish glint in her eyes, serving home-made brew *rak*



LAKSHMAN SINGH NEGI (L), HIMMAT SINGH (R) AND WIFE RAM BHAGATI (C) WITH THEIR KIN, VILLAGE KUPPA, SANGLA VALLEY IN KINNAUR DISTRICT
The two brothers, who inherited 25 bighas of ancestral land, now own 80 bighas of apple orchards, a string of properties and a flourishing fruit trading business.

to her spouses after their day-long toil as orchard workers.

Times, however, are changing and so are traditional practices. Says Ranchan Devi: "Outside culture has invaded Kinnaur, leading to more single spouse weddings". The outside culture has come with the advent of tourism and growing prosperity and education. "The educated Kinnauri youth look down upon polyandry as an uncivilised practice and prefer monogamous marriages," says Digvijay Singh, a 36-year-old post-graduate and up-pradhan of village Kafnu. "Not more than 20 per



"Modernisation has ushered individualism into our conservative tribal society."

CHANDERMANI NEGI

